

The Incident of the Tooth

Mark Twain

Curricular Goals

- identify literary devices and idioms by reading a variety of literature
- recognize basic linguistic aspects and use them in oral and written expression
- express through speech ideas on various aspects of social and cultural surroundings
- write different kinds of letters in appropriate style and register for different audiences and purposes

Competencies

- can understand the meaning and usage of idioms
- can correctly use different types of nouns and pronouns
- can pronounce words with long *i* and short *i* sounds
- can narrate an anecdote and write an informal letter

Reading

a Have you ever made up a story so that you could skip school and stay home? This story is based on an extract from the book, *The Adventures of Tom Sawyer*, set in the fictional town of St Petersburg in nineteenth century America. Tom is an orphan who lives with his Aunt Polly, his half-brother, Sid and his cousin Mary. Read on to find out what happens when Tom comes up with imaginative tales to avoid school.

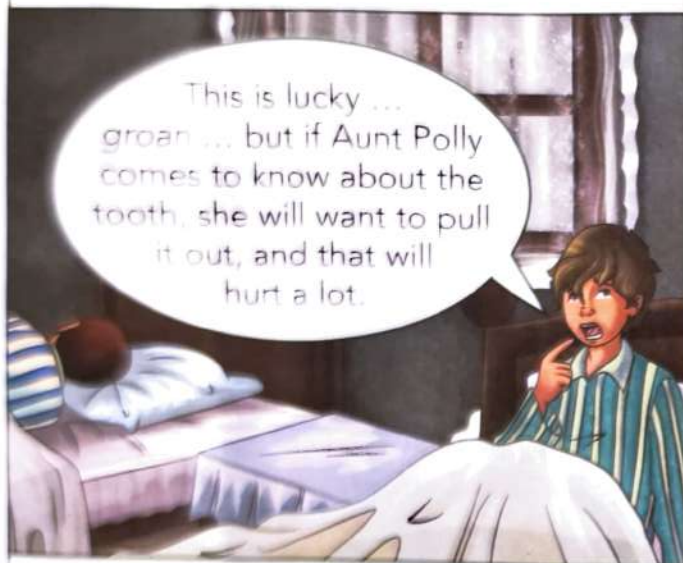
Monday morning found Tom Sawyer miserable. Monday morning always found him so – because it began another week's slow suffering in school.



Tom lay thinking. It occurred to him that he wished he were sick; then he could stay home from school.



But the **colicky** symptoms soon grew **feeble**, and soon, died wholly away. He **reflected** further, and discovered that one of his upper front teeth was loose.



Tom decided to **hold** the tooth **in reserve** for the present and seek further.

Then he remembered hearing the doctor speaking about a certain illness that laid up a patient for two or three weeks. One could even lose a finger from it.



Tom began groaning with spirit, but Sid slept on unconscious.

Tom groaned louder and **fancied** that he began to feel pain in the **toe**.



There was no response from Sid.

Tom was panting with his **exertions** by this time. He rested a moment and then swelled himself up and fetched a **succession** of admirable groans.



Sid snored on.

What did Tom do after resting a moment?



colicky: associated with a stomach ache

feeble: weak

reflected: thought

hold in reserve: keep something available for later use

sore: painful and often, red

fancied: imagined

exertions: great efforts that make someone tired

succession: (here) series

Tom was annoyed now. He called Sid loudly and shook him.

SID!

This worked; Tom fell back and began to groan again.

Tom! Say, Tom!
Here, Tom! Tom!
What is the matter,
Tom?

Oh, don't, Sid.
Don't **joggle** me.

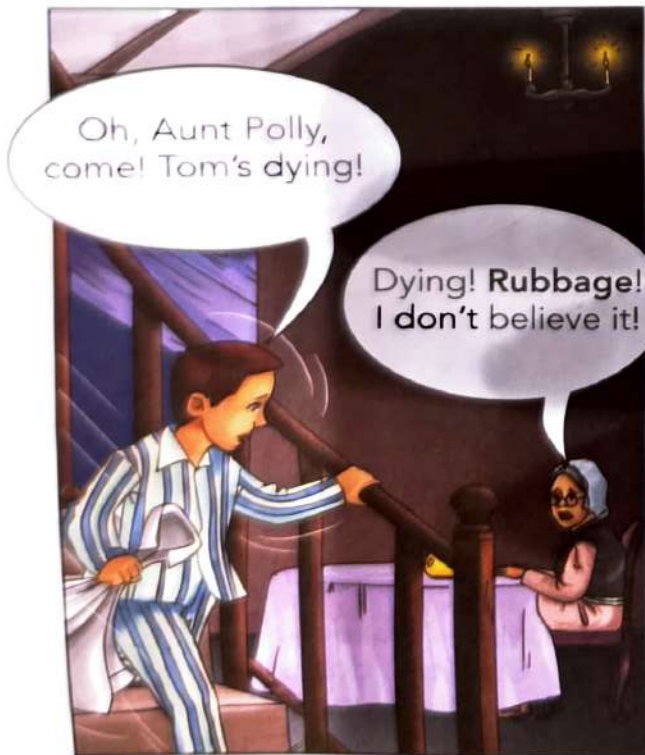
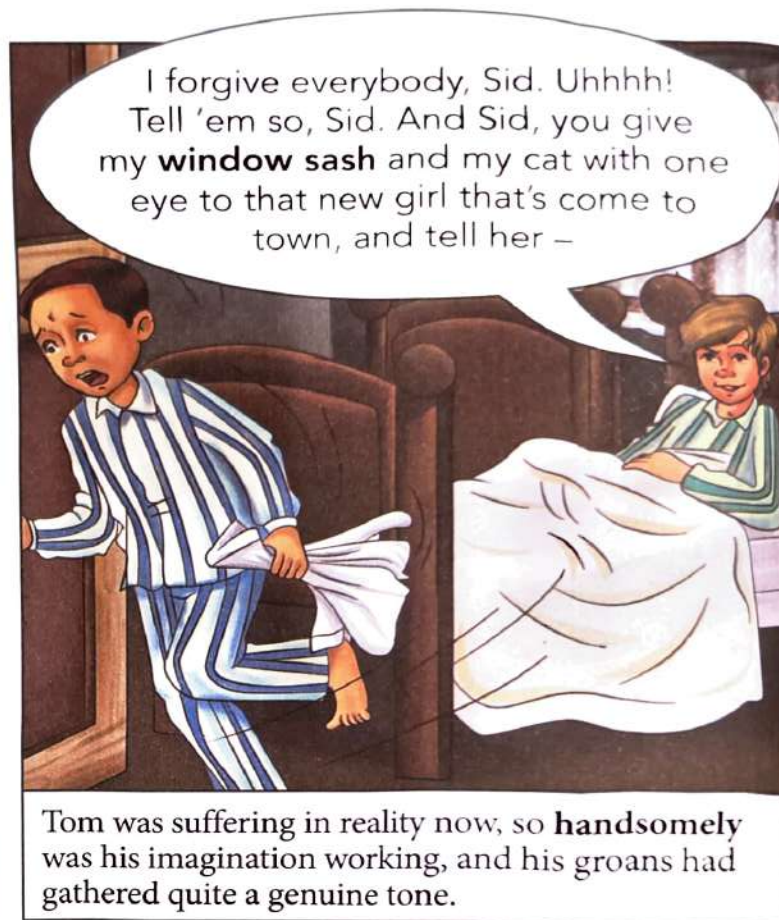
Why, what's the
matter, Tom? I must
call auntie.

No ... never mind.
It will be over by and
by, maybe. Don't call
anybody. AHHHH!

But I must! Don't groan
so, Tom, it's awful.
How long have you
been this way?

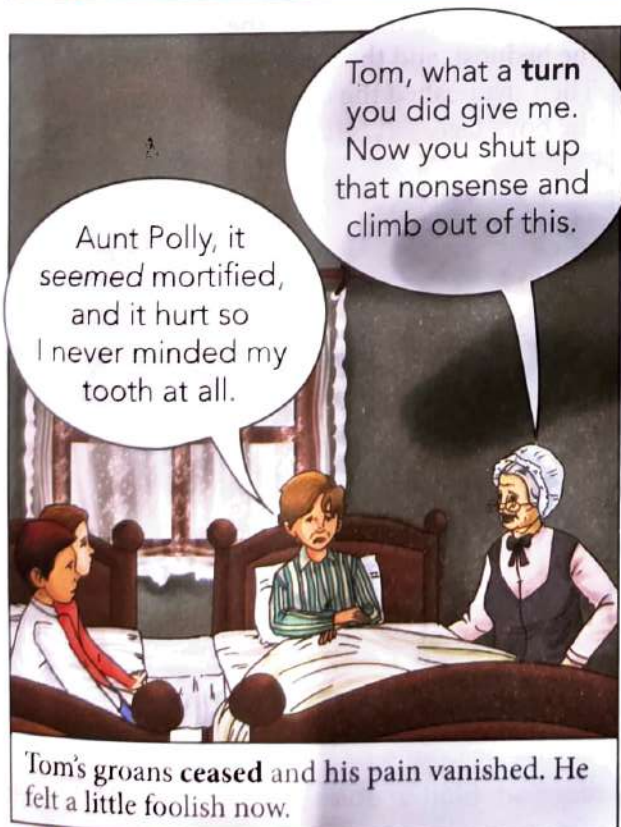
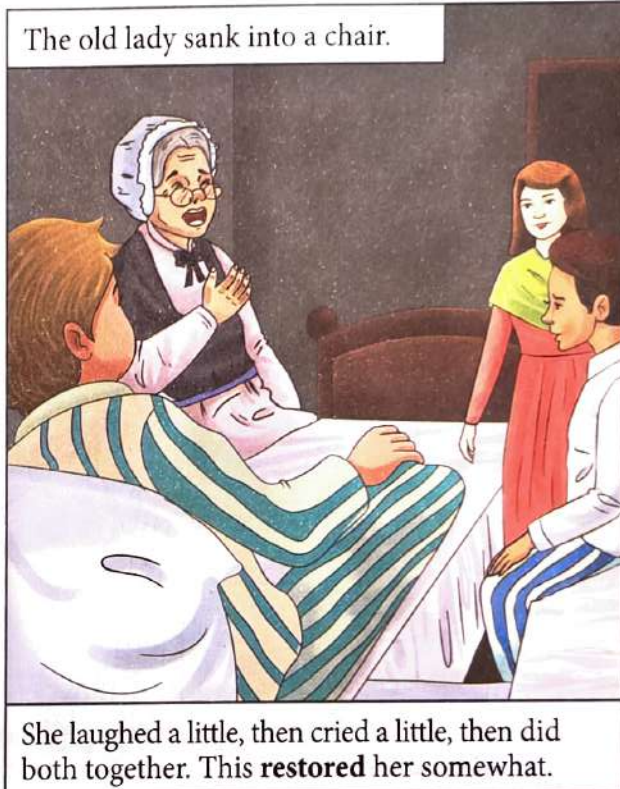
For hours. Ouch!
Don't **stir** so, Sid, you'll
kill me. OHHHHH!

Why didn't you wake me
sooner? Oh, Tom, don't!
It makes my flesh crawl
to hear you. Tom, what is
the matter?



handsomely: (here) successfully
window sash: window frame

rubbage: (here) rubbish



mortified: affected by gangrene, a serious condition which causes tissues in the body to decay

restored: brought back to normal condition

turn: a short period of feeling quite unwell

ceased: stopped

There, there, now, don't begin that groaning again. Open your mouth. Well – your tooth is loose, but you're not going to die of it. Mary, get me a silk thread, and a chunk of fire out of the kitchen.



Cross-curricular Corner

A common home remedy for removing a loose tooth was to tie a string to it and push a glowing coal towards the person's face. Fear of the burning coal would make their head jerk away. Meanwhile, the string, whose other end was tied to a stationary object, would pull the tooth in the opposite direction, thus getting it out.

Oh, please, auntie, don't pull it out. It doesn't hurt any more. I promise not to bother you even if it does. Please don't, auntie. I don't want to stay home from school.



Oh, you don't, don't you? So all this **row** was because you thought you'd get to stay home from school and go a-fishing? Tom, I love you so, and you seem to try every way you can to break my old heart with your **outrageousness**.

Aunt Polly tied one end of the silk thread to the bedpost, and the other end to Tom's tooth. Then she pushed the chunk of fire almost into the boy's face.



Why did Tom lie to everyone?



row: (here) trouble, noise

outrageousness: shocking acts that cross the limits of reason

Common idioms and proverbs

play truant: This idiom means to stay away from school without permission or a genuine reason.



The tooth hung dangling by the bedpost.

But difficult times also bring their rewards. When Tom went to school later that day, he was the envy of every boy because the gap in his upper row of teeth allowed him to spit in a new way. He gathered quite a following of lads interested in the **exhibition**.



exhibition: show

In a Nutshell



About the author

Mark Twain (1835–1910), whose real name was Samuel Langhorne Clemens, was an American author best known for his books, *The Adventures of Tom Sawyer* and *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*. Twain based the books on his childhood memories and experiences.

- | | |
|-------|---|
| Who | Tom, Sid, Aunt Polly, Mary |
| What | Tom's loose tooth is pulled out. |
| How | with the help of a thread and a chunk of fire |
| Why | The tooth was loose. But, Tom didn't want to use this as his excuse for missing school. |
| Where | at home in Aunt Polly's house |

Comprehension

A. Answer the questions.

1. Why did Tom dislike attending school on Mondays?
2. Why did Tom decide to hold the tooth in reserve? What did he think of next?
3. Why did Tom get annoyed with Sid?
4. What did Aunt Polly ask Mary to fetch?
5. According to Aunt Polly, what did Tom do to break her heart?
6. 'But difficult times also bring their rewards.' What was Tom's reward?
7. Do you think Aunt Polly was a sensible woman? Give reasons for your answer.

B. Tick [✓] the correct answers.

- 'Oh, auntie, my sore toe's mortified!' The old lady sank into the chair.
Why do you think the old lady sank into the chair?
a. She was frail. b. She was relieved. c. She was shocked.
- Tom's groans stopped because _____.
a. he was tired b. his tooth was removed c. his lie was found out
- Which of the following did Aunt Polly not use to pull out Tom's tooth?
a. the bedpost b. a silk thread c. a knife
- Tom's tooth was taken out _____.
a. sadly b. forcibly c. carefully
- When Sid woke up, he shook Tom and looked at his face _____.
a. anxiously b. happily c. doubtfully
- Tom fancied that he began to feel pain in the toe.
Which word is a suitable replacement for the underlined word?
a. imagined b. liked c. wanted

Life Skills and Values

being responsible, honesty



- Do you think it is important to consider how our actions can affect others? Explain with examples from the story.
- Can lies be dangerous? Give reasons for your answer.
- Did you think the story was funny? Which sections made you laugh? Explain in your own words.

Vocabulary

abstract nouns

Abstract nouns refer to things which we cannot see or touch but only feel. They include feelings, experiences, **states**, **qualities** and **ideas**.

Example: Tom was suffering in reality now, so handsomely was his **imagination** working.

Abstract nouns can be formed from verbs or adjectives.

Examples: behave → **behaviour** speak → **speech** happy → **happiness**

They are often formed by adding a suffix to the verb or adjective. Sometimes, the word may need to be changed before the suffix is added.

Examples: silly → **silliness** communicate → **communication**

ia A. Form abstract nouns from these words from the story and use them to fill in the blanks.

ill think difficult discovered admirable annoyed

1. The scientist's work led to an important _____.
2. I have the greatest _____ for those who help animals.
3. The doctor prescribed three types of medicines for her _____.
4. I share all my _____, both happy and sad, with my best friend.
5. The loudspeakers are causing _____ to everyone in the area.
6. We found the house without any _____ because of the host's clear directions.

idioms

An **idiom** is a group of words whose meaning is different from the meanings of the individual words. It is usually a combination of a noun and a verb.

Examples: It **makes my flesh crawl** to hear you. (to feel afraid or horrified by something)

Tom, what a **turn** you did **give** me. (frighten or shock somebody)

ia B. Match the idioms with their meanings.

Idiom	Meaning
1. spill the beans	a. change one's way of life to become a better, more responsible person
2. turn over a new leaf	b. not share the same views as somebody about something
3. cost an arm and a leg	c. receiving the benefits of two completely different situations at the same time
4. the best of both worlds	d. very expensive
5. not see eye to eye	e. tell a secret

Now, make sentences of your own with any three idioms.

Grammar

nouns: countable and uncountable, singular and plural

Read this sentence.

Mary, get me some silk **threads**, and a chunk of **fire** out of the kitchen.

Here, the noun **threads** is **countable**. You know that countable nouns can be singular or plural. The word **fire** is an **uncountable noun**.

Language Booster

Not all nouns that end with **s** are plural countable nouns.

Examples: *measles, mathematics, billiards*

ia A. Read these lines from the story and identify the underlined nouns as countable (C) or uncountable (UC).

But difficult times also bring their rewards. When Tom went to school later that day, he was the envy of every boy because the gap in his upper row of teeth allowed him to spit in a new way. He felt joy as they gathered around to watch him show off his new skill.

types of pronouns

You know that pronouns are words that are used in place of nouns to avoid repetition. They are of several types.

Personal pronouns are used in place of the names of people and things. These are *I, we, you, he, she, it, they, me, us, him, her* and *them*.

Examples: *It* occurred to *him* that *he* wished he were sick.

Possessive pronouns are used to show ownership and belonging. They are *mine, yours, his, hers, ours, its* and *theirs*.

Example: The one-eyed cat is *his*.

Reflexive pronouns are used when we want to refer back to the subject of the sentence. They are *myself, yourself, himself, herself, oneself, itself, ourselves, yourselves*, and *themselves*.

Example: He swelled *himself* up and fetched a succession of admirable groans.

ia B. Fill in the blanks with the given pronouns.

herself itself mine she theirs ourselves it hers

1. The books in the cupboard are _____ alone. But the books with Nafisa's name on them are _____.
2. Sally bought a bouquet of flowers for _____.
3. Riya sings so beautifully. _____ takes lessons from a famous musician.
4. Mr and Mrs Apte have known Jacob for years. He is an old neighbour of _____ from Nashik.
5. The cat hissed angrily. Then, _____ began swishing its tail from side to side.
6. The dog looked at _____ in the mirror and barked.
7. We found _____ alone on the empty road, with not a soul in sight.



Study Skills

Pronunciation

long and short *i* sounds



Look at these word pairs and say them aloud. The first word in each pair has the short *i* sound, while the second word has the long *i* sound.

bit – bite pin – pine fit – fine

Read the words aloud and write them in the correct columns.

pipe time sit flight like shin din dine pick shine

short *i* sound as in *pin*

long *i* sound as in *pine*

Listening

listening for facts



Listen to a passage about Mark Twain and fill in the blanks.

1. Mark Twain got his sense of humour from his _____.
2. Twain had _____ siblings.
3. His mother's name was _____.
4. Twain suffered from _____ till he was ten years old.
5. He would test his mother's patience through _____.
6. Years later, when Twain asked his mother if she had been worried that he would not live, she responded, 'I was _____ you would.'

Dictation

You will now listen to a short passage about Tom Sawyer. Write it down. Each sentence will be repeated twice. Listen carefully and try to not make any spelling errors.



Speaking

think-pair-share (financial literacy)



Imagine that Tom was genuinely unwell and had to be taken to the hospital. How do you think people made payments in hospitals in the nineteenth century? Do you think they had cheque books, or did they have to make cash payments? How have modes of payment changed since then? In groups of four, discuss the topic. Then, take turns, in groups, to share your point of view with the class.

Writing

informal letter



In the story, Tom realises that sometimes our mischiefs may come back to bite us. Imagine that you are Tom. Write a humorous letter to your best friend, Huckleberry Finn, telling him about the incident and the lesson you have learnt.

You may include the following points:

- why you came up with the plan
- the various illnesses you thought of
- how you were outsmarted
- your feeling of embarrassment when caught out

Explore More



Read the book *Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* by Mark Twain. It is about the exciting twists and turns in the life of Tom Sawyer's rebellious friend, Huckleberry Finn.



Watch the 1993 film *Dennis the Menace* by Nick Castle about the mischiefs of five-year-old Dennis Mitchell when he is left under the care of his neighbours, Mr and Mrs Wilson.



Listen to the song 'The Boy Who Cried Wolf' by the English singer-songwriter, Passenger. It is based on the classic Aesop's fable, 'The Boy Who Cried Wolf', about a boy whom nobody trusts, as he had lied in the past, even when he is telling the truth.